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Titus

The Greek co-worker Paul trusted with hard places: a test case in Jerusalem, a peacemaker in Corinth, and a builder in Crete.

Titus was a Gentile believer and one of Paul's most trusted partners. Acts never mentions him, so everything we know comes from Paul's letters. As a young man he went with Paul to Jerusalem, where the church leaders did not require him to be circumcised. That made him a living test of the gospel's welcome to Gentiles. Later Paul sent him to the troubled church at Corinth, and his return with good news lifted Paul out of deep distress. He then organized the collection for poor believers in Jerusalem. Finally Paul left him in Crete to appoint elders, and wrote him the letter that bears his name. Titus is a picture of a reliable servant sent into difficult places.

At a glance

Name	Titus, a common Roman name
Background	A Greek, that is, a Gentile, who was not circumcised (Galatians 2:3)
Relationship	Paul's "own son after the common faith" (Titus 1:4)
When	c. AD 46–49 to the AD 60s
Key places	Jerusalem, Corinth, Macedonia, Crete, Nicopolis, Dalmatia
Key people	Paul, Barnabas, the church at Corinth
Main passages	Galatians 2:1–3; 2 Corinthians 2; 7–8; Titus
In Acts	Never named

*"Nevertheless God, that comforteth those that are cast down,
comforted us by the coming of Titus;"*
2 Corinthians 7:6, KJV

The life of Titus

Dates are approximate (AD). *Galatians 2:1* may describe the famine visit (*Acts 11:30*) or the council (*Acts 15*), so the first date could be c. AD 46–49.

c. AD 46–49

Jerusalem

● A test case

Paul takes Titus, a Greek, to Jerusalem with Barnabas. The leaders there do not compel him to be circumcised. Paul treats this as a defense of the gospel's freedom for Gentiles. *Galatians 2:1–5*

c. AD 55–56

Troas

● Missed by Paul

Anxious about Corinth, Paul finds an open door to preach at Troas. Yet he has "no rest in my spirit" because Titus has not arrived, so he moves on to Macedonia. *2 Corinthians 2:12–13*

c. AD 55–56

Macedonia

● Brings good news

Titus reaches Paul with news of the Corinthians' sorrow, repentance and renewed love for Paul. Paul is comforted, and Titus himself is refreshed by them. *2 Corinthians 7:5–16*

c. AD 56

Corinth

● Completes the collection

Paul sends Titus back to finish gathering the gift for the poor believers in Jerusalem. Titus goes eagerly, "of his own accord." *2 Corinthians 8:6, 16–23*

Later

Crete

● Setting things in order

Paul leaves Titus in Crete to "set in order the things that are wanting, and ordain elders in every city." *Titus 1:5*

Later

Nicopolis

● Called to Paul

Paul asks Titus to join him at Nicopolis, where Paul plans to spend the winter. *Titus 3:12*

c. AD 64–67

Dalmatia

● Sent on

In his final letter Paul notes that Titus has gone to Dalmatia. *2 Timothy 4:10*

Key activities

Acts never names Titus, and no one knows why. Everything we know about him comes from Paul's letters.

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- 1 **Stood as a test case.** As an uncircumcised Greek believer, he went to Jerusalem and was accepted. *Galatians 2:1-3*
 - 2 **Handled a painful situation.** After a sorrowful letter from Paul, he went to Corinth and found the church repentant. *2 Corinthians 7:8-13*
 - 3 **Comforted Paul.** God "comforted us by the coming of Titus," Paul wrote. *2 Corinthians 7:6-7*
 - 4 **Loved the Corinthians.** His affection for them grew as he remembered how they received him. *2 Corinthians 7:15*
 - 5 **Led the collection.** He began the gift for Jerusalem's poor and was sent back to finish it. *2 Corinthians 8:6*
 - 6 **Handled money with integrity.** He traveled with trusted brothers so the gift was above suspicion. "Did Titus make a gain of you?" Paul asked. *2 Corinthians 8:16-23; 12:18*
 - 7 **Organized the churches of Crete.** He appointed elders who met clear standards. *Titus 1:5-9*
 - 8 **Taught and modeled sound teaching.** He was to teach every age group and to be "a pattern of good works." *Titus 2:1-8*
 - 9 **Went where he was sent.** He was last seen heading to Dalmatia. *2 Timothy 4:10*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links; Titus is not named in the Old Testament.

Old Testament

Echo: Exodus 18:21	Jethro: share the work with "able men"
Echo: 1 Samuel 12:3	Samuel: "whose ox have I taken?"

New Testament

Galatians 2:1-3	A Greek not compelled to be circumcised
2 Corinthians 2:12-13; 7:5-16	Paul's relief when Titus arrives
2 Corinthians 8:6, 16-23; 12:18	"My partner and fellowhelper"
Titus 1:4-5	Left in Crete; Paul's authorship of the letter is debated
Titus 3:12-13; 2 Timothy 4:10	Called to Nicopolis; gone to Dalmatia
Tradition	Eusebius: first bishop in Crete; later said to die there old

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How did Titus's arrival affect Paul (2 Corinthians 7:5-7)?
2. *Understand:* Why did Paul have trusted brothers handle the collection together (2 Corinthians 8:19-21)?
3. *Apply:* Who could you visit or contact this week with encouragement (2 Corinthians 7:6)?
4. *Apply:* What difficult task might God be asking you to take on rather than avoid?